vandalized the adjacent guard room. The large mob thereafter entered the Tac HQ and set other barracks on fire, including the CO's residence. It was only when the mob attempted to enter the *Kote* (armoury) that the AR were forced to open fire in order to prevent the looting of weapons. This resulted in one more civilian casualty. The restraint shown by the AR, in the face of this intense provocation and fear for their own safety, was most praiseworthy.

The shadow of the Oting incident affected the overall security situation in the state, and multiple underground groups and Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) tried to exploit the incident for their own ends. Immediately after the incident, the Eastern Nagaland People's Organization (ENPO) and Konyak Union (KU) issued a call for their non-cooperation with the SF. There was widespread anger among the public, who saw it as a case of excessive force by the security forces. This anger led to protests and demonstrations, and in some cases, violence against the security forces. Public clamour for repeal of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) increased, and certain areas of Nagaland were removed from the purview of the Disturbed Area Act, to assuage public sentiment.

The entire incident thus had three phases: the initial ambush by the Army; the retaliation by the locals; and the storming of the AR camp the next day. The SF Team immediately realized their mistake and took immediate steps to evacuate the two injured civilians to the hospital, who both survived due to this prompt action. When the locals arrived at the scene, the SF Team had lowered their weapons and were trying to explain the events to the agitated villagers when they were attacked and set upon. The rampage by the mob the next day at Mon had absolutely no justification as the AR had not even been involved in the incident at Oting. The locals were thus the initiators of

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation